

CHAPTER TWELVE

Letting Go — The Practice

Now we come to the stones.

The smooth gray-blue stones that Ms. Calloway had given each child in November and told them to put in their desks. The stones the kids had almost forgotten about — except Theo, who had not forgotten, because Theo never forgets anything, and who had been watching the basket on Ms. Calloway's desk for two weeks waiting for something to happen. The stones were going to be the thing.

On the last Monday before the winter break, Ms. Calloway said: "Everyone, take your stone out of your desk and hold it in your hand." The kids took their stones out. Marcus's stone. Amara's stone. Sofia's. Priya's. Darius's. Jordan's. Maya's. Theo's. Mia's. Kezia's. Ten small smooth stones, in ten small hands.

"Today," she said, "we are going to do a thing. We are going to think of something we are carrying. Something heavy. Something we have been holding on to, maybe for a long time, that we are ready to put down." "You do not have to tell me what it is. You do not have to tell anybody. The stone is just for you and the thing. You are going to hold the stone and you are going to think about the thing. You are going to feel how heavy the thing is, in your hand, as the stone. And then — when you are ready — we are going to put the stones in a basket

together. And we are going to leave the basket on the windowsill. And we are going to walk away."

The kids looked at their stones.

Some of them already knew what their stone was. Marcus's stone was a thing from a long time ago that he had not yet told anyone, that we will not tell you about either, because Marcus has not decided to tell. Sofia's stone was the apples — but it was also other apples, all the small accidents that had felt big to her. Priya's stone was a worry that she was not going to be smart enough. Maya's stone was a question about her mom.

Some of them had to think for a few minutes. Jordan held his stone in his hand and stared at it. He has trouble with this lesson. Jordan does not like to look directly at things that hurt. Jordan likes to make jokes about things that hurt. So Jordan's stone was a little heavier than the others, because Jordan was also having to figure out, for the first time, what was inside it.

Then Ms. Calloway said: "When you are ready, come up. One at a time. Put your stone in the basket. You do not have to say anything. You just put it in."

Marcus went first.

He walked up. He looked at the basket. He put his stone in.

He walked back to his seat.

Sofia went next. Then Priya. Then Amara. Then Theo. Then Darius. Then Kezia. Then Mia.

Maya went second-to-last, very slowly. When she put her stone in, she stood there for a moment. She did not look at the basket. She looked out the window. Then she walked back to her seat.

Jordan was last. He stood up. He walked to the basket. He hesitated. Then — and Ms. Calloway noticed this, and remembered it, and never told anyone — Jordan whispered something to the stone before he put it in. Nobody heard what

he said. Ms. Calloway did not ask. But Jordan put the stone in the basket, and then he walked back to his seat, and his face was different than it had been five minutes ago. Just a little. "Friends," said Ms. Calloway, "the basket is going to stay on the windowsill. The stones are not gone. The things you put down are not gone either. But they are out of your hand. They are not in your backpack. They are out there, in the basket, where you can see them, and where you can come back to them if you need to — but where you do not have to carry them every single day."

She paused.

"This is called letting go. It does not mean the thing did not happen. It does not mean you forget. It means you are choosing — for today — to not carry it."

The kids sat with that.

"And — friends — sometimes the heavy thing comes back. You think you put it down and then in February it shows up again. That is normal. That is not failure. When it comes back, you do this again. You hold it. You feel it. You put it down. As many times as you need to." She looked at the basket on the windowsill.

"This is the practice. This is the whole practice. You will do it for the rest of your life. Putting things down. Picking them up. Putting them down again."

She did not say the next thing out loud, but she thought it: some of you will be doing this when you are forty. Some of you, when you are seventy. The practice is the practice. There is no graduating from it. Then she said: "Okay. The basket stays. Let's read a book."

She read them a book about a bear who was sad, and then happy, and then sad again, and then a friend showed up, and they were sad and happy together. The kids listened. The

basket sat on the windowsill behind her, ten small stones in it, glinting in the winter afternoon light. That night, Maya's grandmother asked her how school was.

"Good," said Maya.

"What did you learn?"

Maya thought about it.

"I learned," said Maya, very slowly, "that I do not have to carry everything all the time."

Her grandmother put her tea down.

"Baby," she said, "I learned that when I was fifty."

Maya did not understand, exactly, why her grandmother got a little teary. But she leaned in and let her grandmother hug her for a long time, and that night Maya slept the deepest sleep she had slept since she came to live with her grandmother in the spring.

The basket of stones is going to stay on the windowsill until June. Some of the kids will come up and look at it. None of them will take their stone back. But sometimes a kid will walk past the windowsill on the way out to recess and pause for a second and look at the basket, and then keep walking.

That is the practice. That is what the practice looks like.